

MARCO LO FASO

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EDUCATION

University of Southern California Los Angeles, CA Ph.D. in Economics	Aug 2021 - May 2027 (expected)
Harvard University Cambridge, MA Visiting Ph.D. Student, Department of Economics	Aug 2025 - August 2026
Bocconi University Milan, ITA M.Sc. in Public Policy and Political Economy	Sept 2016 - March 2019
Bocconi University Milan, ITA B.Sc. in Economics	Sept 2013 - Sept 2016

RESEARCH FIELDS

Applied Microeconomics, Spatial Economics, Political Economy

RESEARCH

“The Geography of Protests: Spatial Fragmentation, Mobilization and Backlash in the George Floyd Movement”

Abstract This paper studies how urban geography shapes protest dynamics and their downstream effects on voting behavior. I geocode 5,785 George Floyd protest events across 374 U.S. metropolitan areas and document significant spatial fragmentation: protests take place simultaneously at multiple venues within the same city. Combining these geocoded sites with mobile phone location data, I measure foot traffic flows between neighborhoods and protest venues at the census-tract level. I then estimate the effects on political outcomes, exploiting differences in protest exposure and participation across neighborhoods within the same metropolitan area. The results reveal two opposing mechanisms. First, a localized backlash: neighborhoods within one kilometer of protest sites experience significant increases in Republican vote share, with effects that decay rapidly with distance and are amplified by violence. Second, a countervailing mobilization channel: neighborhoods whose residents visited protest areas saw increased Democratic vote share and higher turnout, even after controlling for local exposure. Protest fragmentation—shaped by urban structure—expands both participation and exposure, generating offsetting political effects whose balance depends on the spatial organization of protest within cities.

“The Labor Market Returns to Religious Networks: Evidence from Uganda” (with Aruj Shukla)

“Selfish Parents: Children Migration, Schooling Investment and Political Preferences”

EXPERIENCE

University of Southern California <i>Research Assistant for professor Augustin Bergeron</i>	May 2023 - Dec 2023
Pompeu Fabra University Barcelona, ESP <i>Research Assistant for professor Ruben Durante</i>	Sept 2020 - Aug 2021
Bocconi University Milan, ITA <i>Research Assistant for professor Vincenzo Galasso</i>	Sept 2019 - Aug 2020
European Central Bank Frankfurt, GER <i>Research Intern</i>	Jan 2019 - Aug 2019
European Commission Brussels, BEL <i>Economic Analyst</i>	Aug 2017 - Apr 2018

ACADEMIC WORK, EXPERIENCE AND SERVICE

Teaching Assistant, University of Southern California ECON 318 – Introduction to Econometrics – Italo Lopez Garcia (undergraduate) ECON 436 – Political Economy and Economic Development – Augustin Bergeron (undergraduate) ECON 305 – Intermediate Macroeconomics – Jaime Meza (undergraduate) ECON 501 – Macroeconomic Analysis and Policy – Jaime Meza (master)	Sept 2022 - May 2024
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Teaching Assistant, Bocconi University

Sept 2019 - Aug 2020

*Welfare and Politics – Vincenzo Galasso (master)**Economics of European Integration – Carlo Altomonte (master)**Political Economics – Vincenzo Galasso (undergraduate)**European Economic Policy – Carlo Altomonte (undergraduate)***ACES Summer School in Political Economy, UC Berkeley**

Aug 2023

Summer School in Economics of Migration, Global Migration Center UC Davis

Sept 2024

Co-organizer – Southern California Graduate Conference in Applied Economics, USC

Oct 2023

GRANTS AND AWARDS

Dean's Dissertation Completion Fellowship (for "The Geography of Protests"): \$21,218.00

Lusk Research Center for Real Estate Research Award (for "The Geography of Protests"): \$15,000.00

Dan James Fellowship (for "The Geography of Protests"): \$40,000.00

Weiss Fund Research Grant (for "The Labor Market Returns to Religious Networks"): \$5,000.00

USC Summer Research Award (x3): \$4,000.00

MISCELLANEOUS**Programming Skills:** Python, R, Stata, Matlab**Languages:** Italian, English**Other:** Born June 9, 1995, Citizenship: Italian, Visa Holder: F1 (USA)

REFERENCES**Thomas Chaney (Chair)**

John Elliott Chair in Economics and Professor of Economics

Department of Economics

University of Southern California

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Augustin Bergeron

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Last updated: April 2026